Conclusion

The fluidity that confronts India in the Indo-Pacific region will require flexibility and dextrous handling. A rising China creates uncertainty. It is not known for sure whether China seeks hegemony, if this would come at the expense of cooperation based on mutual benefit for the region, and if China can rise peacefully. These uncertainties are a challenge for India. Interdependence through institutions and economic cooperation in Asia will raise the threshold beyond which clash of political interests and confrontation could become conflicts, but it cannot prevent them altogether. States will increasingly fall back on balance-of-power measures for their security. India will therefore seek closer relations with the United States, as will a host of other states in the Indo-Pacific with similar concerns as India. India also has to factor in the increasing disinclination of the United States to shoulder the burdens of global leadership and the eroding certainty of its resolve to stand up for friends and allies.

Given this fluidity and uncertainty, India will neither bandwagon with China nor participate in a balancing coalition. Moreover, India’s inheritance and instincts militate against these two options. India would prefer a policy that combines constructive cooperation with China and at the same time enables India to strengthen its strategic ties with other countries, including the United States.

The medium- to long-term interests of the established and emerging great powers converge, including those of the United States, China, Russia, Europe, India, and Japan. Their common interests on major global and regional issues – including preserving and promoting global and regional public goods, which straddle energy, environment, global pandemics such as COVID-19, and proliferation – require cooperation. The pervading sense of crisis should impel